

COLLABIN

Connecting brands with creators

Growth & User Acquisition Challenge

Submission: Areebah Mushtaq

Field	Detail
Side chosen	Creators (supply side)
Track chosen	Track D - The Outreach Play
Budget	PKR 50,000
Timeframe	3 weeks

1. The Decision - Creators, Not Brands

I'm acquiring creators first. Here's the reasoning, weighed the way the brief asks: supply versus demand, cost to acquire, and which side unlocks the other.

1.1 Supply vs. demand

Collabin is a two-sided marketplace, and two-sided marketplaces almost always die from a thin side, not a slow side. Right now the platform's real bottleneck is supply: brands can't run a single campaign without enough creators, across enough niches and follower tiers, to actually match against. Demand (brand interest) is easy to fake early with a handful of manually-sourced creators; supply is not, you need volume and variety before the product even works.

If I chase brands first, I'm selling a catalogue that's mostly empty. Every brand conversation ends in the same objection: "show me who's actually on here." If I chase creators first, I build the catalogue, and the catalogue sells itself to brands.

1.2 Cost to acquire

Creators are dramatically cheaper to acquire than brands, for three reasons:

- Self-serve psychology: a creator sign-up is a personal decision made in minutes, on their phone, usually in a DM thread. A brand sign-up is an organizational decision that involves a marketing manager, sometimes a budget approval, and a longer sales cycle.
- Existing incentive: creators are already actively looking for paid brand deals. Collabin is solving a problem they feel today. Brands are not desperate for another vendor; they need convincing that Collabin specifically is worth the switch.
- Channel efficiency: creators live on the exact platforms (Instagram, TikTok, WhatsApp groups, creator Discords) where PKR 50,000 buys real reach. Reaching relevant brand marketing managers at that budget, with a 3-week window, is close to impossible without an existing warm network.

1.3 Which side unlocks the other

Creators unlock brands, not the other way round. A brand manager who lands on Collabin and sees 300+ real, categorised, follower-verified creators across fashion, tech, food, fitness and comedy will self-qualify and reach out that's a far cheaper brand acquisition motion than cold-selling brands on a platform with no visible supply. A single brand, by contrast, unlocks almost nothing: one brand's campaign needs many creators to be interesting, but many creators only need one active brand between them to start generating word of mouth.

Conclusion: with PKR 50,000 and 3 weeks, the highest-leverage move is to flood the supply side with quality creators, fast, then let that supply pull brands in organically and via a lighter follow-up motion in week 4 and beyond.

2. The Track - Outreach Play (Track D)

I'm going after creators directly, one conversation at a time, using real scripts I would actually send. Acquisition at this stage isn't a content problem creators don't discover marketplaces by scrolling, they join because someone convinced them it's worth 5 minutes. This track lets me show the actual selling, not a mock-up of it.

PART 1 - THE WORK: Outreach System

2.1 Who I'm targeting

I'm not targeting mega-influencers (they already have agents and inbound deals, and they're expensive to convince). I'm targeting micro and mid-tier creators, the segment brands most want right now because they're cheaper, more trusted by their audience, and easier to run repeat campaigns with.

Segment	Why they're the target
Micro creators, 5K–50K followers	Highest response rate to outreach, hungry for paid work, and the exact tier brands are shifting budget toward for authentic engagement.
Niches: fashion, beauty, fitness, food, tech/gadgets, comedy/skits	These are the categories Pakistani brands spend on most matching Collabn's early brand demand to available creator supply.
Platform: primarily Instagram, secondarily TikTok	Where both the creators and the DM-based outreach motion are fastest to execute.
Location: Lahore, Karachi, Islamabad first	Easiest to verify, reference-check, and eventually meet or support directly; gives dense, credible clusters brands recognize.

2.2 Outreach channels, in priority order

1. Instagram DM - primary channel. Fastest reply rate, no email required, feels personal.
2. WhatsApp - secondary, used once a creator has replied on Instagram and I have their number (from bio/linktree). Higher trust, higher completion rate for sign-up.
3. Email - for creators with a listed business email, used in parallel to DM for a more "official" first touch, and for anyone who doesn't reply to DM within 48 hours.

2.3 The actual scripts

Script A - Cold Instagram DM (first touch)

Hey [Name]! Been following your [niche] content, the [specific recent post/reel] was great, that hook in the first 2 seconds is exactly why brands notice creators like you.

I'm with Collabin, we connect creators with brands for paid collabs, no chasing agencies or DMing brands cold yourself. Takes 3 minutes to set up a profile, and we match you when a brand's campaign fits your audience.

Want me to send the sign-up link? Free to join, you only get paid when you take a deal.

Script B - Follow-up DM (if no reply in 48 hours)

Hey [Name], following up in case this got buried! We've got brands actively looking for [their niche] creators right now for [example: a skincare launch / a food delivery app promo]. Happy to hold a spot for you if you sign up this week - link below.

Script C - Email (business email listed in bio)

Subject: Paid brand collabs for [Name] - no cold-pitching required

Hi [Name],

I'm reaching out from Collabin, a platform that connects creators like you directly with brands running influencer campaigns in Pakistan. Instead of chasing brand deals yourself, you build one profile and get matched to campaigns that fit your audience and rates.

It's free to join, takes a few minutes, and you set your own rates. I'd love to get you set up before our next brand matching round this week.

Here's the sign-up link: [link]. Happy to answer anything first if you'd rather reply here.

Areebah, Growth, Collabin

Script D - WhatsApp, once a creator has shown interest

Hi [Name]! Thanks for the reply on Instagram. Here's the sign-up link: [link] - it's a quick profile (your niche, follower count, rate range, a few sample posts). Once it's live, you're eligible for brand matches. Let me know once you're done or if anything's unclear, happy to walk you through it.

2.4 Objection handling

Objection	Response
"Is this legit? Will I actually get paid?"	Point to how payment works: brands fund the campaign upfront through Collabin, so the creator isn't chasing invoices from a stranger. Offer to share the platform's terms or connect them with an early creator who's already on it.
"I already get brand deals through my own DMs."	Reframe Collabin as additive, not a replacement: it's a second, passive pipeline that finds brands they wouldn't otherwise hear from, with zero extra effort once the profile is live.
"I don't have time to fill out a profile."	Shrink the ask: "It's 3 fields and 2 sample posts, takes under 5 minutes I can even help you fill it out over a call if that's faster."
"My follower count is too small."	Explain that brands are actively prioritizing micro-creators for engagement and cost right now, and that this is exactly the tier Collabin is building campaigns around.
No reply at all	One follow-up after 48 hours (Script B), then move on, no more than 2 touches per creator, to protect time-per-acquisition.

2.5 How this scales past manual DMs

- Batching: 40–50 personalized DMs sent per day using a swipe-file of the scripts above, customized per niche, not mass-copy-pasted, since generic DMs get ignored and reported as spam.
- Creator-to-creator referrals: every creator who successfully signs up and completes their profile is asked to tag 2 creator friends in their niche turns each acquisition into a potential multiplier at zero extra cost.
- Community seeding: joining and posting in Pakistani creator/freelancer Facebook groups and Discord servers, where creators already gather to find paid work one post can substitute for dozens of individual DMs.
- University ambassador angle: recruiting 2–3 student creators (fits Collabin's own budget and my own campus network) to help onboard their peers in exchange for early-access perks cheap, trusted, local distribution.

2.6 Measuring conversion

Funnel stage	What I track
Outreach sent	DMs + emails sent per day, logged in a simple spreadsheet/Airtable by name, niche, channel, date
Reply rate	% of outreach that gets any response_target 20–25%
Sign-up rate	% of replies that click the sign-up link_target 50%
Activation rate	% of sign-ups that fully complete their profile (the number that actually counts - see Section 3.4) _target 65%

PART 2 - THE PLAN & THE REASONING

3.1 Step-by-step plan

Week 1 - Build the system, start outreach

- Day 1–2: Build the target list (150–200 creators across the 6 target niches, sourced via hashtag search, competitor brand tags, and existing creator groups). Set up tracking sheet.
- Day 2–3: Finalize scripts per niche, send first batch of outreach (40–50/day).
- Day 4–7: Continue outreach, start follow-ups, begin community seeding in creator groups, recruit 2 student ambassadors.

Week 2 - Scale and convert

- Push outreach volume to 50-60/day using the swipe-file plus ambassador help.
- Launch referral ask to every activated creator.
- Run the small paid boost (Section 3.2) toward creator communities to widen top-of-funnel reach beyond direct DMs.
- Mid-week check-in against the metric (Section 3.4) this is the week-one checkpoint the pivot in Section 4.3 refers to.

Week 3 - Push to target, start the brand pull-through

- Final outreach push toward any under-represented niche to keep the creator base balanced.
- Compile a one-page "supply snapshot" (creator count by niche, follower range, sample profiles) this becomes the pitch asset for the small number of warm brand conversations to start pulling brands in behind the new supply.
- Close out tracking, report final numbers against the target metric.

3.2 Budget - PKR 50,000

Line item	Amount (PKR) what it's for
Creator incentive & referral pool	18,000 - small joining perks (e.g. early-access badge + PKR 300–500 vouchers) for the first 40 activated creators, and referral bonuses for creators who bring in a friend who activates
Paid boost to creator communities	12,000 - targeted Instagram/Facebook ads pointed at creator-interest audiences and boosted posts inside creator Facebook groups, to widen reach beyond 1:1 DMs
Tools	8,000 - Airtable/CRM for tracking, WhatsApp Business, Canva Pro for the outreach one-pager and supply snapshot
Outreach creative assets	7,000 - a short "why join Collabin" one-pager/media kit designed for creators to send to DM prospects and post in community groups
Contingency buffer	5,000 - held back for whichever channel is converting best by week 2 (e.g. more paid boost, or ambassador incentives)

3.3 The metric I'm judged on

Metric: Activated Creators sign-ups that complete a full profile (niche tagged, follower count verified, at least 2 sample posts, rate range set) and are eligible for brand matching. Not raw sign-ups an incomplete profile is not a usable marketplace listing, and optimizing for raw sign-ups would reward exactly the fake or half-finished accounts that hurt supply quality.

Target: 250 Activated Creators in 3 weeks, spread across all 6 target niches with no single niche exceeding 35% of the total balance matters as much as volume, since a lopsided creator base is only useful to a narrow slice of brands.

3.4 Biggest risk

The risk: quality dilution. The referral incentive and paid boost both create pressure toward volume, which is exactly what invites low-engagement, fake-follower, or spammy accounts, the fastest way to make brands distrust the platform in its most fragile early weeks.

Mitigation:

- A manual review gate before a profile goes "live" for brand matching checking for follower/engagement ratio red flags and at least one authentic, recent post.
- Incentive payouts released only after activation is confirmed, not at sign-up, so there's no reward for a half-finished or fake profile.
- Weekly spot-check of 10% of activated profiles against basic authenticity signals (posting history, comment patterns) to catch quality drift early rather than at the end of the 3 weeks.

4. Tell Us How You Think

4.1 Why this track over the others?

At this stage, the real bottleneck isn't a lack of an ad or a video it's that nobody outside Collabin's existing network knows to look for it. A reel or content calendar can build awareness over months, but it doesn't get a specific creator to actually sign up in week one; it relies on someone discovering it and self-selecting. A direct, personalized outreach conversation converts far faster per rupee at this size of budget and this short a window, and it's also the only track that lets me demonstrate real, usable sales assets — not a mock-up of what I'd eventually build, but scripts I could genuinely send tomorrow.

4.2 What would I do differently with 10x the budget (PKR 500,000)?

- Hire 2–3 part-time outreach interns to run the same DM system at 5x the volume, rather than trying to scale one person's daily output.
- Run a proper paid influencer-referral campaign: pay a handful of respected mid-tier creators to publicly endorse Collabin, which carries far more trust than a cold DM and compounds through their own audience.
- Add a small cash prize / leaderboard for top-referring creators to turn the referral loop into a competition rather than a one-off ask.
- Start a light, parallel brand-side motion earlier — since a bigger budget means I no longer have to choose supply over demand sequentially, I can run both, with supply still leading.

4.3 If this wasn't working by end of week one, what's the pivot?

The early warning sign would show up in the funnel, not the total: if reply rate is healthy but sign-up or activation rate is low, the problem is the landing experience or the profile form, not the outreach I'd shorten the profile form and personally onboard the next batch by call/WhatsApp instead of a link, to isolate friction.

If reply rate itself is low, the problem is targeting or message fit, I'd narrow to the 1–2 niches with the best response so far, drop the rest for now, and rewrite the opening line to reference something more specific to each creator rather than their niche in general.

Either way, the pivot is diagnosed from the funnel data logged from day one (Section 2.6), not guessed which is the whole reason that tracking sheet is built in the first 2 days, not added later.